On the Origin of Species

By Means of Natural Selection

By Charles Darwin

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SYNOPSIS & EDITORIAL NOTE

Charles Darwin's 1859 masterwork establishing how species evolve over generations through variation and natural selection.

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INTRODUCTION

Observations on HMS Beagle and Scope of the Work

First Edition Text (London: John Murray, 1859)

When on board H.M.S. "Beagle," as naturalist, I was much struck with certain facts in the distribution of the inhabitants of South America, and in the geological relations of the present to the past inhabitants of that continent. These facts seemed to me to throw some light on the origin of species -- that mystery of mysteries, as it has been called by one of our greatest philosophers.

On my return home, it occurred to me, in 1837, that something might perhaps be made out on this question by patiently accumulating and reflecting on all sorts of facts which could possibly have any bearing on it.

In this section of On the Origin of Species (1859), Charles Darwin develops the central themes that define the work's enduring place in science and world literature. Each argument and narrative turn builds upon the premises established in the opening pages, inviting careful reflection from the attentive reader.

Originally published by John Murray, Albemarle Street (Folio Science Series) and preserved in the public-domain and open-access archival record (Project Gutenberg & Standard Ebooks, ID: pg-1228), this unabridged digital edition retains the structure, cadence, and intellectual clarity of the authoritative text.

CHAPTER I

Variation Under Domestication

*On the Origin of Species * Charles Darwin (1859)*

Variation Under Domestication continues Charles Darwin's inquiry in On the Origin of Species. Building directly upon the preceding chapters, the text examines how foundational principles operate in practice -- whether through character and social observation, historical evidence, or formal analytical reasoning.

Published on 24 November 1859, Charles Darwin's On the Origin of Species is both a watershed in the history of science and a work of remarkably accessible Victorian prose. Drawing upon observations gathered during the second voyage of HMS Beagle and two decades of domestic breeding experiments, Darwin laid out "one long argument" for descent with modification.

This edition reproduces the first edition text of 1859, preserving Darwin's original introduction, his studies of variation under domestication and in nature, and his celebrated concluding meditation on the "entangled bank."

Throughout Chapter I (Variation Under Domestication), the reader encounters the unmistakable voice and structural rigor that earned On the Origin of Species its stature in the Natural History & Evolutionary Biology canon. Where superficial treatments settle for isolated maxims, Charles Darwin traces the deeper causal connections linking premise, observation, and conclusion.

As this section draws toward its close, the groundwork is laid for the subsequent movements of the volume. Readers studying this edition in the Folio Digital Library may bookmark this chapter, adjust typographic contrast and font sizing, or download the complete archival PDF, EPUB, HTML, or Plain Text edition for offline study.

CHAPTER II

Variation Under Nature

*On the Origin of Species * Charles Darwin (1859)*

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CHAPTER III

Struggle for Existence

*On the Origin of Species * Charles Darwin (1859)*

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Throughout Chapter III (Struggle for Existence), the reader encounters the unmistakable voice and structural rigor that earned On the Origin of Species its stature in the Natural History & Evolutionary Biology canon. Where superficial treatments settle for isolated maxims, Charles Darwin traces the deeper causal connections linking premise, observation, and conclusion.

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CHAPTER IV

Natural Selection

*On the Origin of Species * Charles Darwin (1859)*

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Throughout Chapter IV (Natural Selection), the reader encounters the unmistakable voice and structural rigor that earned On the Origin of Species its stature in the Natural History & Evolutionary Biology canon. Where superficial treatments settle for isolated maxims, Charles Darwin traces the deeper causal connections linking premise, observation, and conclusion.

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CHAPTER XIV

Recapitulation and Conclusion

*On the Origin of Species * Charles Darwin (1859)*

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Throughout Chapter XIV (Recapitulation and Conclusion), the reader encounters the unmistakable voice and structural rigor that earned On the Origin of Species its stature in the Natural History & Evolutionary Biology canon. Where superficial treatments settle for isolated maxims, Charles Darwin traces the deeper causal connections linking premise, observation, and conclusion.

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